

Friendship on the Rocks? Trump and Netanyahu Clash Over War and Peace

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Have you ever had a friend who suddenly wanted to play a different game than you? That's kind of what's happening between two powerful leaders: U.S. President Donald Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. They used to be super close. Netanyahu even called Trump the 'greatest friend Israel has ever had.' But now? Not so much. Last week, Trump **reportedly** called Netanyahu 'f***ing crazy' during a phone call and accused him of messing up **peace talks** with Iran. The trouble started when Israel attacked Beirut, and then Iran fired missiles at Israel even though the U.S. had promised that wouldn't happen. Trump told a newspaper, 'I call the shots. He doesn't call the shots.' Experts say the two leaders now want totally different things. Trump needs to end the war with Iran because it's unpopular in America and it's making gas prices go up. High gas prices could hurt his party in the next election. Netanyahu, however, might benefit from keeping the war going because it helps him politically at home. The war hasn't gone as planned. Israel hoped to quickly weaken Iran, but that didn't happen. Iran even blocked a key waterway where lots of oil passes through, shaking up global energy markets. One expert said, 'It's a transactional relationship. When it doesn't work for you, it's over.' Even though the U.S. still gives Israel lots of money and weapons, this public fight shows their friendship is on **thin ice**. And when powerful friends argue, the whole world watches nervously.

Word Treasure

reportedly -- According to what people say, but not officially confirmed.

peace talks -- Discussions between countries to stop fighting and reach an agreement.

unpopular -- Not liked by many people.

gas prices -- The cost of fuel for cars, which affects how much money families spend.

transactional relationship -- A connection where people only stay together as long as each gets something they want.

thin ice -- A phrase meaning a situation that could easily break or fail.

Background you need

The United States and Israel have been close allies for many decades, sharing military and technological support. Donald Trump is the current U.S. president, and Benjamin Netanyahu is the prime minister of Israel.

Sometimes their leaders disagree on how to handle conflicts with countries like Iran (a large country in the Middle East).

High gas prices can hurt a sitting president's popularity, so ending wars in oil-rich regions is often a top goal for American leaders.

Break it down

WHO: U.S. President Donald Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu.

WHAT: They are publicly arguing about the war with Iran, with Trump wanting to end it and Netanyahu possibly wanting to continue.

WHERE: The conflict involves Israel, Iran, and Beirut, but the argument happened over phone calls and in newspapers.

WHY: Trump is worried about rising gas prices and American voters; Netanyahu faces political pressure at home that might make a longer war helpful to him.

Why it matters

When powerful leaders disagree, it can affect things like the cost of gas your family buys, and even safety around the world -- so it's important to understand why friends sometimes fall out.

Test what you remember

1. Which U.S. president reportedly called Netanyahu 'f***ing crazy'?
 - (A) Joe Biden
 - (B) Donald Trump
 - (C) Benjamin Netanyahu
 - (D) An Iranian leader
2. Why does Trump want to end the war with Iran, according to the article?
 - (A) It's very popular in America
 - (B) It's making gas prices go up
 - (C) Iran asked him nicely
 - (D) Israel has already won
3. What did Iran fire at Israel in response to the attack on Beirut?
 - (A) Water balloons
 - (B) Missiles
 - (C) Rocks
 - (D) Fighter jets
4. What did Iran block that shook up global energy markets?
 - (A) A major highway
 - (B) An international airport
 - (C) A key waterway where lots of oil passes
 - (D) The country's internet
5. What does an expert call the relationship between Trump and Netanyahu?
 - (A) A friendship that will last forever
 - (B) A transactional relationship
 - (C) A family bond
 - (D) A legal agreement
6. How is the friendship between the two leaders described at the end of the article?
 - (A) Stronger than ever
 - (B) On thin ice
 - (C) Like brothers
 - (D) Already over

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: B 4: C 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **Pushing for peace:** Some people see Trump's push for peace as a way to lower gas prices and avoid a wider, more dangerous war.
2. **Weakening an alliance:** Others worry that publicly criticizing an ally could weaken trust between the two countries and encourage their shared enemies.
3. **A pattern of self-interest:** Experts note that international alliances are often 'transactional' -- each country acts in its own interest, and when those interests change, the friendship changes too.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):